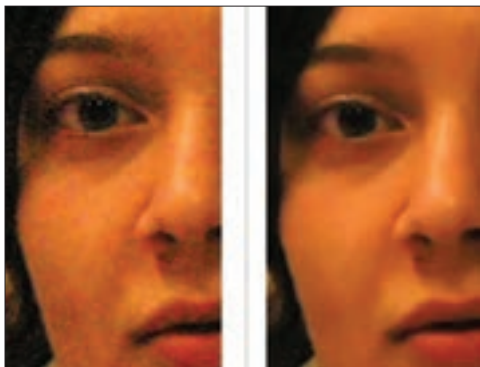


ISO number. This means slower shutters and larger openings. The point that most of us miss, however, is that there is just one sensor in the digital camera that cannot be replaced as easily as a roll of film. At any given point in time, the number of pixels stays the same. Changing the ISO, therefore, has no impact on the detailing of the image. But, strangely, increasing the ISO speed, similar to film cameras, the quality of the image dwindles due to noise.

Noise

Visual noise is unwanted interference that hinders the accurate perception of the image. In digital images, *noise* appears as *graininess* – specks of phoney colour. The longer the exposure, the more noise, but for normal photography, a sensor manages to produce a bearable and consistent degree of noise. Noise levels vary according to (a) the size of the sensors and its pixels, (b) the processing algorithm and (c) lighting conditions.

As in photographic film cameras, low ISO speeds produce very low noise. Instead of chemical grains, however, high ISO settings force the processor to amplify a weaker signal. It now fails to



The nose on the left is 'noisier'

recognise the difference between real-image data and noise, and therefore, amplifies everything leading to a lousy picture. In more technical terms, the lower the signal-to-noise ratio (S/N), the noisier the photos.

About all the DSLRs (digital single lens reflex cameras) in the market give you images with minimal noise at lowest ISO settings – about ISO 100-200. Certain compact digital cameras work best at ISO 50-100. The newer digicams often give noisy